National
Qualifications
2022

X827/76/11

ESOL
Listening Transcript

THURSDAY, 26 MAY

9:00 AM – 9:45 AM (approx)

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Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 1

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should ideally be read by one male and one female speaker. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

(t) Recording 1

Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice.

You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Nick You're listening to the Outdoor Show. It's Friday, I'm Nick Gordon, lovely to have you with me. We are jam-packed with things to do outdoors over the next two hours. We're going to be celebrating Doors Open Day at 30 and there's a Viking festival in Largs. Now, let's make a start with wild swimming.

I go to the local pool about once a week and I enjoy a swim in the sea when I'm somewhere warm, like Spain or Greece, but I haven't swum outdoors in Scotland since I was a kid on family holidays, and it was really cold. But my first guest swims in the sea and rivers and lochs in Scotland and she claims to enjoy it. Please welcome Clara Mitchell. Clara – hello.

Clara Hi there.

Nick So Clara, what does it mean to be a wild swimmer?

Clara Well, it essentially means swimming outdoors in natural spaces, such as rivers, lochs or the sea. It's seen a real surge of enthusiasm in recent years.

Nick Isn't it a bit cold?

Clara Yes, it is, though you can wear a wetsuit. That helps, but a lot of wild swimmers just wear a normal swimming costume, though I find with a wetsuit I can stay in a bit longer. Whatever you're wearing, when you drive yourself under you still get a freezing skull. But when you come through this, you can get a real buzz at the other side.

Nick But . . . isn't there a risk of hypothermia – if you stay in too long?

Clara There sure is. The last swim I did, last Monday, it was a beautiful morning and my friend and I swam for around half an hour. The water temperature was pretty normal, between six and seven degrees. I even did a few handstands. I was wearing a wet suit, but one so old and ill-fitting that it was almost pointless. But then I knew I'd stayed in a little too long because I started to feel strange and giddy. So I got out, drank a gallon of hot tea, and took half the day to warm up.

Nick That's scary. So how long have you been wild swimming?

Clara It's been about a couple of years now. Many wild swimmers swim on their own but I joined a group because I like being part of a community. These are people who come to the sea and find joy in it. They come with their anxieties and their grief, and find, for a moment or even longer, it freezes them all away. They come here to play, but also, often, for a kind of therapy.

Nick Can you explain how that works?

Clara I think there's a growing appreciation that we're not meant to be cut off from nature. Think of it, for thousands of years humanity existed in close proximity to the natural world – hunting, gathering and later farming. And only for the last couple of centuries have most people lived a different life in towns and cities.

Nick Yes, but you can get close to nature by going for a walk in the local park.

Clara Of course, but with wild swimming you also have the challenge – you're doing something that most people can't or won't do. When I started, the first swims were tough. But my body quickly learnt to look forward to the zing that would follow. One local wild-swimmer says, 'The only advantage I have over new swimmers is knowing how amazing it feels afterwards.'

Nick I don't think that's going to get me back in the sea, but you think there are some psychological benefits from wild swimming?

Clara Well, there have been medical studies looking into the benefits. There's a case report, which showed that a programme of cold-water swimming had led to a reduction in symptoms of depression.

Nick That's encouraging to hear. *(said with enthusiasm)*

Right, thank you Clara, and I hope you'll stick around for some reaction from the listeners. *(begin fade)* Have you tried wild swimming? How did it work out for you? You can contact us on . . .

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 2

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 2

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You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Presenter Many things can stop people from applying for a job in the retail or service sector: a lack of self-confidence, for example, or concerns about fitting in with future colleagues. My friend jokes that she 'could never work in a designer clothes shop because her hair's too frizzy'. That might seem ridiculous, but actually, she could be right. Are we heading towards a situation where style is more important than skills? Here to help us answer that question is Chris Campbell, manager of a well-known coffee house chain. Hi Chris.

Chris Hi, thanks for having me.

Presenter Chris, a report was published last month questioning the image certain employees project and the image would-be employers want to promote. Do you agree that it's important for café staff to reflect the lifestyle being sold by their place of work?

Chris Absolutely. Employees need to reflect what the company stands for. Our coffee shop chain, —

Presenter *(interrupting)* Is that even more important than having the relevant experience or skills?

Chris Well, practical skills are important, but they can easily be picked up on the job. We're not talking rocket science here. It's far easier to train someone to make a cup of coffee than it is to change their personality! Employers want someone who reflects their brand and dresses accordingly.

Presenter So it's about appearance – basically you're looking for good-looking, stylish and trendy applicants? And young, no doubt!

Chris Well, I wouldn't put it quite like that. You can be stylish and not so young . . .

Presenter But basically the ideal employee would closely resemble a young cast member of a trendy soap. Isn't that the image you want to portray?

Chris *(laughs)* Look, we pitch ourselves as a continental, cultured place and we want staff who fit this image. There's nothing wrong with that.

Presenter So even though your company's registered in the UK, you'd need a continental accent to work there?

Chris No, no, any accent's fine . . . as long as it's not too . . . regional.

Presenter Regional? Heaven forbid they'd have a Glasgow accent!

Chris I just mean not too strong. You see, what we're trying to do here is create a solid, established identity in all of our UK stores and ensure that every one of them looks the same.

Presenter With regard to how coffee houses look, is it a case of familiarity breeds contentment in the consumer, and, of course financial benefits for the companies?

Chris It's not just the look – a good atmosphere's really important. You can't blame us for wanting to find the right employees to help create an appealing image.

Presenter The worrying aspect about this trend is the discrimination it brings against others who might not be so 'trendy', like the long-term unemployed.

Chris Look, the service industry's growing rapidly and there are plenty of jobs out there. Anyone can put in an —

Presenter *(interrupting)* But not just anyone can get the jobs, can they? Unemployment levels are staying the same in many areas, like the east end of Glasgow, despite the growth. The report points out that the long-term unemployed are being overlooked in favour of middle-class kids with more cultural experience.

Chris As long as the applicant's polite and clean, . . .

Presenter The report highlights that it's *not* a matter of café's not hiring people with poor personal hygiene, or undesirable behaviour. It gives an incredibly unfair example of employee discrimination, with one woman who was sent home and told to shave her legs. This kind of thing is actually breaking the law, as the report points out.

Chris That sounds a bit extreme! We always ensure there's no unfair discrimination, while trying to portray the right image.

Presenter According to the report, therein lies the problem, because that's exactly what creating an image means – promoting certain qualities at the expense of others. In this case, these qualities happen to be employees, and this is the inevitable result when capitalism meets the concept of selling a lifestyle in a coffee cup. When it comes to places like cafés and restaurants, the customer wants to be served, simple as that. If the takeaway coffee you bought was watery and the service was slow, it's unlikely you'll go back there, no matter how young and stylish the barista is.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 3

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 3

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(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

(m/f) Hello, everyone. I'm Jamie Sullivan and I'm going to be talking to you about bad science in relation to keeping fit. To start off, how many of you walked here this morning? Put your hands' up . . . right, about half of you. And raise your hand if you regularly walk at least 10,000 steps a day. *(pause)* Significantly fewer than half! Well, it's the 10,000-steps-a-day regime that I'm going to focus on first today. As I'm sure you're aware, this fitness regime has become part of our popular culture. You can barely walk down the street without someone stomping past you using the obligatory step counter in their quest to reach 10,000 steps. And that's not just in Scotland – it's become a global obsession. The latest research estimates that by 2022 there'll be 600 million step counter consumers across the world, striving to reach this goal, despite the fact that 10,000 steps is a completely arbitrary figure.

The figure of 10,000 originates from a successful Japanese marketing campaign in the mid-60s. In an attempt to take advantage of the immense popularity of the 1964 Tokyo Olympics, the company Yamasa designed the world's first wearable step-counter, a device called a manpo-kei, which translates as '10,000-step meter'. There wasn't really any evidence for it at the time – they just felt that was a number that was indicative of an active lifestyle and should be healthy. A research team began to investigate the potential benefits of taking 10,000 steps. They concluded that the average Japanese person took between 3,500 and 5,000 steps a day, and that if these people increased their daily step count to 10,000, they could decrease their risk of heart disease.

But while the World Health Organisation and the American Heart Foundation have gradually adopted 10,000 steps as a daily activity recommendation, recently the accuracy of this number has been called into question. You see, many experts believe that there's no health guidance that exists to back it. Indeed, most of the scientific studies that have been conducted to try to test whether 10,000 steps a day is optimal for health are themselves relatively arbitrary. They simply compare people who've done 10,000 steps a day with those who have done far lower numbers, such as 3,000 or 5,000, and then measure calories burned, blood pressure and so on.

For those who have a long-term illness or for older people who are used to a more inactive lifestyle, there are now concerns that making a rapid jump to 10,000 steps a day could actually have negative effects. For others, the target may seem too high and may actually discourage them from increasing their daily physical activity. There seems to be an obsession with the target of 10,000 steps. On the other hand we know that sedentary lifestyles are bad, and if you're taking fewer than 5,000 steps a day on average this can lead to increased health risks. Let's not forget that it's more important, from a public health point of view, to stop people from just sitting around, especially as a significant number of Brits walk for just 10 minutes a day. So the question we should really be asking is: 'how many steps are too few?'

Some studies suggest that somewhere between 6,000 and 8,000 steps could be the lower boundary to aim for. But while the rise of the step-counter industry has led to a generation of fitness lovers fixated on achieving 10,000 steps, there is also currently no upper limit on how much is good for us. Sport scientists are now trying to conduct studies to see whether 15,000 or even 18,000 steps have long-term health benefits over the traditional 10,000 benchmark.

One of the major problems with the 10,000-steps-a-day goal is that it doesn't take into account the intensity of exercise. Getting out of breath and increasing your heart rate may be even more important than the exact number of steps taken. Researchers are currently conducting studies to see whether people who take 10,000 steps a day merely by pottering around their house achieve the same health benefits as those who do so by brisk walking or playing sport.

This is just the beginning of this area of research and just one example of bad science in sports. Now let's move on to the next example . . . *(fade)*

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

(t) You now have one minute to check your answers.

(*1 minute pause*)

(t) This is the end of the listening test.

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